(i.e. the removal of Saddam) before they would agree to the lifting of sanctions.

Key question
How did Iraq survive UN sanctions?

The impact of sanctions on Iraq

From the end of the war in 1991, Iraq was subjected to a blockade which prevented it from importing machinery, fertilisers, most medicines and even books. At first Iraq was not allowed to sell oil and, even when this ban was lifted after a few months, Iraq was still allowed to sell only a small amount of oil. As a result, the country could afford only very modest food imports and, in a country which had been importing 70 per cent of its food, this had disastrous consequences. Sanctions led to hardship and poverty on a massive scale. Malnutrition and a huge rise in infant mortality were reported. A UN survey in the mid-1990s claimed that, in the Baghdad area, a quarter of those under the age of five years old were 'severely malnourished' (a higher proportion than in most African states) and, by 1997, 7000 children were dying each month of hunger and disease.

The bombing of electricity plants in the war had led to a breakdown of the water purification systems, yet Iraq was not allowed to import chlorine as a water disinfectant for fear it might be a source of the chlorine gas used in chemical weapons. The contamination of water led to widespread outbreaks of dysentery. It is reckoned that between a quarter and half a million children died as a result of sanctions and Saddam's rule. As the humanitarian crisis worsened, the UN came up with a plan in 1996 to allow Iraq to sell its oil in order to buy food. This 'Oil for Food' programme was to be run by the UN. It brought much-needed relief to a desperate people.

Yet sanctions did not increase the opposition to Saddam's regime in Iraq, let alone lead to rebellion. Instead, they led to a widespread feeling of hopelessness while the rationing of food meant that the government could control who received food and thus ensure that the regime's key supporters were given priority. Saddam used violence and terror, as ever, to control resources and reward his most loyal supporters. Disloyal elements in the army were purged, sometimes executed. A special army unit was created to protect the President and nearly all the top jobs in government and the armed forces went to Sunnis, particularly to members of Saddam's own family and tribe.

The roads, bridges and electricity systems in Baghdad and the Sunni areas were largely rebuilt and, although Iraq's WMD programme was depleted, the army was still the biggest in the Arab world. Meanwhile Saddam allowed the filming of mass suffering, especially for Arab television networks, so that the image of Iraq as the victim of the greedy, uncaring West would be propagated. International opinion turned against the continuation of sanctions.